

While I might have been a little disappointed that my whole class couldn't go bowling or play mini-golf every year, it saved my family a lot of money in the long run and made the birthday parties that we *did* have extra special!

Besides, on the “off” years, you can still make the birthday special by doing an activity that would be too stressful to do with a large group. Or, you can have a special evening out at a favorite restaurant, then come back for cake and ice cream with immediate family.

2. MAKE YOUR OWN CAKE

One of the craziest things I ever did straight out of college was own my own cake business for a couple of years. It was fun while it lasted, but I quickly found out that cake decorating just wasn't my life's passion. The stress of getting brides their cake in one piece, and spending hours with a piping bag in my hand took their toll, and I decided I wasn't cut out for that line of work. Still, I am very thankful I have the skills to create bakery-inspired cakes at home, and guess what? You can do it too!

Not every baked good needs to be *Cake Boss* worthy, but a few basic skills will help you go far. Pretty soon you'll be able to create a simple, but pretty party cake with ease. My favorite way to learn cake decorating techniques is to sign up for a course at A.C. Moore or Michaels, but if you'd rather practice in the comfort of your own home, I recommend a [Craftsy.com](https://www.craftsy.com) class.

Even a few dozen cupcakes can look professionally decorated without a lot of effort. My favorite decorating tip to use is 1M from the Wilton collection, and it creates a very pretty swirl on top of each cupcake. Sprinkle with a dusting of colored sugar, and everyone will think you had the local bakery cater your event.

3. PLAN AN INEXPENSIVE MENU

Whether you're planning a meal for a large party or a smaller, more intimate one, don't feel like you have to provide a gourmet dinner for every birthday. A simple soup buffet in the winter or hot dogs and hamburgers in